

"We primarily look for people with good programming skills"

As an online tutoring platform, TutorVista customises open source applications to mimic a classroom experience and maintain its database. G Ramasubramani, CTO, TutorVista, tells *LFY* readers what skills the company looks for while hiring, and how open source has helped the management cut costs and maintain stability of operations.



G Ramasubramani, CTO, TutorVista

Q Please tell us about the FOSS professionals who currently work at TutorVista.

Our technology team, which includes developers, testers and the entire IT team, consists of about 35 to 40 people. They are based in Bengaluru and work in an entirely start-up-like environment. This has been created to make them feel that we are super-nimble and super-fast at what we develop. Agility is the main reason why we have an internal tech team. We want to make changes really fast. We want to push the modifications out, experiment, see if they are helping or harming the process, and roll them back if they don't work or tweak them based on input and feedback. The working environment is very agile and people are urged to mingle with each other, understand what is going on, evaluate the impact of changes based on what others are doing as well, and make fixes quickly. As a result, releases are out much more frequently and sooner than others. We cannot do this if we make changes slowly.

Q What kind of open source implementations have been made in TutorVista?

We have always used the LAMP stack. There are servers for content, database and database slaves, load balancing, and the ejabberd server. At present, we have about 50 LAMP-based servers. We use Linux for the operating system, while all our servers are Linux-based, and all the Web servers are Apache-based. Our programs were mainly developed using PHP, but of late, we have been trying to use Java and Tomcat to build some additional tools. We are also working with one of the new technologies coming up in Java called Wicket, to get some other things done. Wicket is under the open source Web framework. It is component-based and removes all the plumbing work that you need to do when you are developing a website, allowing you to focus on your business problems. We are checking if we can use it to become more productive.

Q What do you look for in FOSS professionals while hiring?

We primarily look for people with good programming skills. We check for how well they know programming, how they can program through a language and not how well they know the language. We like people who have experience with open source technologies and know how to figure out what to use and where to search for it. We look for logic and how candidates think through a problem to come up with a solution. We check how applicants can implement algorithms, how well they can improve something and make it perform better. When we solve a problem, we often pick a very sub-optimal approach – so we look at how to tune that sub-optimal solution to make it work better. Once they show us they know how to program, then we go into the language.

If you are a senior person, we check how well you know the Web application server life cycle. We want to know whether your expertise is not just about developing something, but how you deploy it and go into production; what is the production architecture; how will you deal with the issues in production; we need to be clear about your understanding of an entire gamut of the full life cycle of what goes on. In addition, at a senior level, you are expected to understand the impact of technology on business as well. At the junior level, we check whether applicants know the basics of programming and we can take care of the rest.